

AP U.S. GOVERNMENT & POLITICS · THE UNIVERSAL STUDY GUIDE

Foundational Docs · 15 SCOTUS Cases · 5 Units · 4 FRQ Types · The 4-vs-5 Differentiator

Tag legend: [FLOOR—4] = floor (must-have) [STRETCH—5] = what makes the difference for a 5

PAGE 1 | THE MATH OF YOUR TARGET · 5 BIG IDEAS · WHAT TO MEMORIZE**THE MATH OF YOUR TARGET — what you need to score (~75% of total)**

Section	Weight	Total Available	Get this many	What that takes
MCQ	50%	55 questions	41 / 55 (~75%)	Eliminate, never blank, dominate the source-based questions
FRQ 1: Concept App	9%	3 points	3 / 3	Direct A/B/C answers tied to the scenario
FRQ 2: Quant Analysis	12%	4 points	3–4 / 4	Identify pattern → draw inference → connect to politics
FRQ 3: SCOTUS Comp	12%	4 points	3–4 / 4	Know the clause behind each required case + facts/holding
FRQ 4: Argument Essay	17%	6 points	5–6 / 6	Thesis + 2 evidence (1 from foundational doc) + reasoning + rebuttal

That's the 5. The argument essay alone is 17% of your grade — nailing one foundational document and one specific second piece can turn a 4 into a 5 by itself.

THE 5 BIG IDEAS — every FRQ ties back to one of these

Code	Big Idea	What it captures
CON	Constitutionalism	Founding ideas, ratification debates, federalism, separation of powers, checks and balances
LOR	Liberty and Order	Civil liberties (Bill of Rights) vs civil rights — the classic individual-rights-vs-state-interest balance
PRD	Civic Participation in a Representative Democracy	Voting, parties, interest groups, media, public opinion — the linkage institutions
PMI	Competing Policy-Making Interests	Branches interact; policy is shaped by ideology, public opinion, parties, interest groups
MPA	Methods of Political Analysis	How to interpret data, polls, and political behavior; quantitative reasoning

WHAT YOU MUST MEMORIZE COLD — the only memorization that really matters

[5] AP Gov rewards memorization more than any other AP. The list is short and concrete:

- **9 Required Foundational Documents** (Page 2 — argument essay literally requires citing one)
- **15 Required SCOTUS Cases** (Page 3 — SCOTUS Comparison FRQ requires you to recall one cold, including the constitutional clause)
- **Constitutional clauses by name:** Necessary and Proper, Supremacy, Commerce, Full Faith and Credit, 10th Amendment, Establishment, Free Exercise, Equal Protection, Due Process
- **Selective Incorporation** — applying Bill of Rights to states via 14th Amendment due-process clause (key cases: Gitlow, McDonald)
- **The 5 Constitutional Compromises** (Great, 3/5, Slave Trade, Electoral College, Commerce)

MASTER CHEAT STRIP — the 9 docs + 15 cases at a glance

9 Foundational Documents: *Declaration of Independence* · *Articles of Confederation* · *U.S. Constitution* · *Federalist 10* (Madison) · *Federalist 51* (Madison) · *Federalist 70* (Hamilton) · *Federalist 78* (Hamilton) · *Brutus 1* (Anti-Federalist) · *Letter from Birmingham Jail* (MLK)

15 SCOTUS Cases: *Marbury* · *McCulloch* · *US v. Lopez* · *Engel v. Vitale* · *Wisconsin v. Yoder* · *Tinker* · *NYT v. US* · *Schenck* · *Gideon* · *Roe* · *McDonald* · *Brown v. Board* · *Citizens United* · *Baker v. Carr* · *Shaw v. Reno*

PAGE 2 | THE 9 FOUNDATIONAL DOCUMENTS · the Argument Essay requires one

[5] On the Argument Essay (FRQ 4), one of your two evidence pieces **MUST** come from a required foundational document. If you can recall the right doc + its specific argument + one quote-or-paraphrase, you've earned a guaranteed point. Below, the table maps each doc to the prompts where it's most useful.

Document (Author, Year)	Big Idea	Key Argument	Use it for prompts about...
Declaration of Independence (Jefferson, 1776)	CON	Natural rights, social contract, government's just powers come from "consent of the governed"; right to revolution.	Founding ideology, popular sovereignty, government legitimacy, equal rights
Articles of Confederation (1781)	CON	First U.S. gov; weak central authority — couldn't tax, no executive, no national court. Showed need for stronger federal gov.	Limits of state power, why we need federalism, weak central gov critiques
U.S. Constitution (1787)	CON	Created federal system, separation of powers, checks and balances, amendment process, Bill of Rights (1791).	Almost any prompt — but most powerfully on federalism, branches, rights
Federalist 10 (Madison)	CON, PRD	Large republic best controls factions ; pluralism makes any single faction unable to dominate.	Factions, parties/interest groups, why a large diverse republic works
Federalist 51 (Madison)	CON, PMI	"If men were angels..." Separation of powers + checks and balances. "Ambition must be made to counteract ambition."	Separation of powers, checks and balances, federalism, branches
Federalist 70 (Hamilton)	CON, PMI	Argues for single, energetic executive — "energy in the executive" essential for good gov.	Presidential power, unitary executive, Article II powers
Federalist 78 (Hamilton)	CON, PMI	Defends judicial independence, lifetime tenure, judicial review; courts are the " least dangerous branch " (no purse or sword).	Judicial review, court power, judicial independence, judicial activism debates
Brutus 1 (Anti-Federalist, 1787)	CON	Anti-Federalist — opposed Constitution; warned a large republic threatens liberty and concentrates power; necessary & proper + supremacy clauses too broad.	Limits on federal power, states' rights, original Anti-Federalist concerns
Letter from Birmingham Jail (MLK, 1963)	LOR, PRD	Justifies civil disobedience against unjust laws; "injustice anywhere is a threat to justice everywhere." Distinction between just and unjust laws.	Civil rights, civil disobedience, the moral/legal tension, equal protection

HOW TO USE A FOUNDATIONAL DOC IN THE ARGUMENT ESSAY [5]

The score-earning move: name the doc + paraphrase one specific argument from it + connect it directly to YOUR thesis.

Template: "*Federalist 51* argues that '**ambition must be made to counteract ambition**' — Madison's case for separation of powers. This supports my thesis because [direct connection to your claim about the modern issue]."

Common mistake [4 trap]: vaguely "the Constitution says X." Bad. Cite a **specific clause, amendment, or article** and tie it to your claim. "Article I, Section 8's necessary and proper clause grants Congress..."

DOC-TO-PROMPT QUICK MATCHING [5]

If the prompt is about...	Reach for these docs first
Federalism / state vs federal power	Federalist 51 (separation), Brutus 1 (federal overreach), Constitution (10th Amend., Supremacy Clause)
Presidential power	Federalist 70 (energetic executive), Constitution (Art. II)
Judicial review / court power	Federalist 78 (judicial independence), Constitution (Art. III)
Voting / parties / participation	Federalist 10 (factions), Constitution (15th, 19th, 24th, 26th Amend.)
Civil rights / equality	Letter from Birmingham Jail (MLK), Declaration of Independence ("all men are created equal"), Constitution (14th Amend.)
Civil liberties / individual rights	Constitution / Bill of Rights , Brutus 1 (need for explicit protections)
Why we have any government at all	Declaration of Independence (consent), Federalist 51 ("if men were angels")

PAGE 3 | THE 15 REQUIRED SCOTUS CASES · know the CLAUSE, not just the case

[5] On the SCOTUS Comparison FRQ (FRQ 3), you'll get a non-required case and need to compare it to a required one. Score-earning move: identify the CLAUSE both cases share, then explain how the required case's reasoning applies. Knowing the clause behind each required case is the 5-vs-4 differentiator.

Case (Year)	Clause	Holding (1-line)	Why it matters / Use it for prompts about...
Marbury v. Madison (1803)	Art. III	Established judicial review — courts can strike down laws	Most powerful tool the courts have. Use for any prompt about court power, separation of powers, checks and balances.
McCulloch v. Maryland (1819)	Necessary & Proper + Supremacy	Federal gov has implied powers ; states can't tax federal institutions	Federalism, broad federal power, implied powers, federal supremacy
US v. Lopez (1995)	Commerce Clause	Limits on Commerce Clause — Gun-Free School Zones Act struck down ; not all activity is "commerce"	Limits on federal power , federalism, state autonomy. Counter to McCulloch's expansive view.
Engel v. Vitale (1962)	1st Amend. Establishment	Public school prayer is unconstitutional — even voluntary, even non-denominational	Establishment Clause, religion in schools, separation of church and state
Wisconsin v. Yoder (1972)	1st Amend. Free Exercise	Amish exempt from compulsory school past 8th grade — religious freedom outweighs state interest	Free Exercise, religious liberty, balancing state and religious interests
Tinker v. Des Moines (1969)	1st Amend. Speech	Students don't "shed their constitutional rights at the schoolhouse gate" — symbolic speech (black armbands) protected	Student speech, symbolic speech, civil liberties in schools
NYT v. United States (1971)	1st Amend. Press	No prior restraint on Pentagon Papers; gov must show overwhelming need to censor	Press freedom, prior restraint, gov secrecy vs public's right to know
Schenck v. United States (1919)	1st Amend. Speech	Speech can be limited if it creates a " clear and present danger " (yelling "fire" in a theater)	Limits on speech, wartime restrictions; later replaced by Brandenburg's "imminent lawless action"
Gideon v. Wainwright (1963)	6th + 14th (incorporated)	States must provide attorneys to felony defendants who can't afford one	Right to counsel, selective incorporation , due process for the accused
Roe v. Wade (1973)	14th Amend. Due Process	Right to privacy includes abortion (overturned by Dobbs 2022)	Privacy rights, due process, judicial activism, <i>stare decisis</i> (or its limits)
McDonald v. Chicago (2010)	2nd + 14th Amend.	Incorporated 2nd Amend. to states — individual right to bear arms applies to state/local laws	Selective incorporation (key example!), 2nd Amend., federalism + rights
Brown v. Board of Education (1954)	14th Amend. Equal Protection	Overtured Plessy — "separate is inherently unequal"; segregation in schools unconstitutional	Civil rights, equal protection, judicial role in social change
Citizens United v. FEC (2010)	1st Amend. Speech	Corporations + unions have free-speech rights; independent campaign expenditures can't be limited → super PACs	Campaign finance, money as speech, parties/interest groups, controversial decisions
Baker v. Carr (1962)	14th Amend. Equal Protection	"One person, one vote" — federal courts CAN hear redistricting cases (justiciable)	Redistricting, voting equality, judicial role in elections
Shaw v. Reno (1993)	14th Amend. Equal Protection	Racial gerrymandering unconstitutional — districts drawn predominantly by race violate equal protection	Gerrymandering, voting rights, race-based districting

SCOTUS COMPARISON FRQ — the 4-step recipe [5]

(1) Identify the **CLAUSE** in the new case (usually 1st Amend., 14th Amend., or Commerce). (2) Match to a required case sharing that clause: Speech → Tinker/Schenck/Citizens United/NYT; Equal protection → Brown/Baker/Shaw; Free Exercise → Yoder; Establishment → Engel. (3) State the required case's facts + holding in 1–2 sentences. (4) Explain how the holding applies to (or differs from) the new case — this is the comparative-reasoning point.

UNIT 1 | FOUNDATIONS OF AMERICAN DEMOCRACY

Theories of Democracy — know which theory each scenario reflects

Theory	Core idea + example
Participatory	Broad participation in politics + civil society. Example: town halls, voter initiatives, referenda.
Pluralist	Group-based participation; multiple competing groups influence policy. Example: NAACP, NRA, AARP all lobbying. <i>Federalist 10</i> supports.
Elite	Political/economic elites disproportionately shape policy. Example: Citizens United enabling wealthy donors; revolving door.

Articles of Confederation → Constitution: why we made the switch

- **Weaknesses of Articles:** no power to tax, no executive, no national court, 9/13 needed for laws, **unanimous** consent for amendments, couldn't regulate interstate commerce. **Shays' Rebellion (1786)** exposed it.
- **Constitutional Convention compromises:** **Great Compromise** (bicameral: House by population, Senate 2/state); **3/5 Compromise**; **Slave Trade** (couldn't ban until 1808); **Electoral College**; **Commerce** (only fed regulates interstate).
- **Federalists** (pro-Constitution: Madison, Hamilton, Jay) vs **Anti-Federalists** (Brutus, Patrick Henry — wanted Bill of Rights, feared centralized power).

Federalism — the spine of every "who has authority" question

Concept / Era	What it means
Dual federalism (1789–1937, "layer cake")	Federal & state govs operate in separate spheres
Cooperative federalism (1937–60s, "marble cake")	Federal & state work together via grants and joint programs (New Deal expanded this)
New federalism (Reagan onward)	Devolution — push power back to states via block grants
10th Amendment	Powers not given to fed are reserved to states or the people — Anti-Federalist victory
Necessary & Proper Clause (Art I §8)	Implied powers — basis of broad federal action (McCulloch)
Supremacy Clause (Art VI)	Federal law overrides conflicting state law
Commerce Clause	Most expanded federal power. Lopez = limits
Full Faith and Credit Clause	States must honor each other's laws/judgments
Block grants vs Categorical grants	Block: state discretion (broad area). Categorical: narrow purpose, fed-defined.
Mandates (funded vs unfunded)	Fed requires states to do something; unfunded = controversial (states pay)

Separation of Powers + Checks and Balances

[5] Cite Federalist 51 on this topic. "Ambition must be made to counteract ambition." Each branch checks the others.

Branch	Checks on the others	Held in check by
Congress	Override veto (2/3); impeach president/judges; approve treaties (Senate); confirm appointments; declare war; power of the purse	Presidential veto; judicial review
President	Veto; pardons; commander-in-chief; appointment; executive orders; treaties (with Senate)	Congressional override; impeachment; judicial review
Courts	Judicial review (Marbury); life tenure for independence	Confirmation by Senate; impeachment; jurisdiction set by Congress; constitutional amendment can override

Amendment Process [4]

- **Proposal:** 2/3 of both houses of Congress, OR 2/3 of state legislatures call a convention. **Ratification:** 3/4 of states (38) — by legislature OR convention. *Designed to be hard* — only 27 amendments in 230+ years.

UNIT 2 | INTERACTIONS AMONG BRANCHES OF GOVERNMENT

CONGRESS — bicameralism is the master concept

Feature	House (435 reps)	Senate (100, 2/state)
Term	2 years (entire House up each cycle)	6 years, staggered (1/3 up)
Constituency	District (smaller, more partisan)	Whole state
Min. age	25	30
Leadership	Speaker of the House , Majority/Minority Leaders, Whips	President of Senate (VP), President pro tempore , Majority/Minority Leaders
Distinct powers	Originates revenue bills; impeaches officials	Confirms appointments; ratifies treaties (2/3); tries impeachments
Debate rules	Rules Committee — strict time limits	Filibuster (60 votes for cloture); unlimited debate

How a bill becomes a law: Introduced → Committee → Subcommittee → Markup → Floor → Other chamber → Conference Committee → Veto/Sign.

- **Standing committees** (permanent), **Select** (temporary), **Joint** (both chambers), **Conference** (reconcile House/Senate versions).
- **Pork barrel / Earmarks:** targeted spending for districts. **Logrolling:** trading votes. **Discharge petition:** force a bill out of committee (218 House signatures).
- **Trustee vs Delegate vs Politico:** Vote your conscience / your district / a mix. **Partisan polarization** has surged since the 1990s.
- **Gerrymandering:** partisan or racial redistricting. **Baker v. Carr** made districts justiciable; **Shaw v. Reno** banned racial gerrymandering.

PRESIDENT — formal vs informal powers

Type	Examples
Formal powers (in Constitution)	Veto, commander-in-chief, treaty-making (with Senate), appointments, pardons, State of the Union, recommend legislation
Informal powers	Executive orders (force of law, no Congress); executive agreements (no Senate ratification, but only binds current admin); bully pulpit ; signing statements ; going public

- **EOP (Executive Office of the President):** White House staff, OMB (budget), NSC, Council of Economic Advisers. Created 1939.
- **War Powers Act (1973):** president must notify Congress within 48 hrs of deploying troops; can't continue past 60 days without authorization. Commonly ignored.
- **Cite _Federalist 70_** for arguments about a strong, single executive.

THE COURTS — judicial review is the engine

- **Article III** — federal courts. Three levels: **District (94)** → **Circuit Courts of Appeals (13)** → **Supreme Court (9)**. **Marbury (1803)** established judicial review.
- **Original vs appellate jurisdiction.** SCOTUS has *original* in cases involving states or ambassadors; mostly hears appellate cases via **writ of certiorari** (rule of 4 — needs 4 justices to grant).
- **Stare decisis:** respect for precedent. **Overtured:** Plessy → Brown; Roe → Dobbs.
- **Judicial activism vs restraint:** Activism = courts willing to strike laws / change precedent; Restraint = defer to elected branches.
- **Originalism vs Living Constitution:** Originalism = interpret as Founders meant; Living = principles evolve with society. (Scalia/Thomas vs Brennan/Ginsburg.)
- **Cite _Federalist 78_** on judicial independence + lifetime tenure.

BUREAUCRACY — the "4th branch"

- **Cabinet departments** (15, e.g., State, Defense, Treasury); **Independent agencies** (NASA, CIA); **Regulatory commissions** (FCC, SEC, FTC); **Government corporations** (USPS, Amtrak).
- **Iron Triangle:** long-term alliance between **agency + congressional committee + interest group**. **Issue networks:** looser, more dynamic.
- **Rule-making + discretionary authority:** agencies fill in legislative gaps. **Oversight:** Congress (hearings, GAO), President (appointments, OMB), Courts (judicial review).

UNIT 3 | CIVIL LIBERTIES & CIVIL RIGHTS

Civil Liberties vs Civil Rights — the AP loves this distinction

[5] **Civil liberties** = protections **FROM** government (Bill of Rights). **Civil rights** = protections **BY** government from discrimination (14th Amend., Civil Rights Act 1964).

BILL OF RIGHTS — drill these, you'll need them on MCQs

#	Topic	Substance
1	Speech / press / religion / assembly / petition	Establishment, Free Exercise, Speech (incl. symbolic), Press, Assembly, Petition
2	Right to bear arms	Incorporated to states via McDonald (2010)
3	No quartering of troops	Rarely tested
4	Searches & seizures	Need a warrant + probable cause; exclusionary rule (Mapp v. Ohio)
5	Self-incrimination, double jeopardy, due process, eminent domain	"Plead the 5th"; Miranda rights stem from this
6	Speedy/public trial, jury, right to counsel	Gideon v. Wainwright — counsel for indigent felony defendants
7	Civil jury trial	Federal civil cases > \$20
8	No cruel and unusual punishment, no excessive bail/fines	Death penalty, prison conditions
9	Other rights retained	Catch-all (basis for unenumerated rights, e.g., privacy)
10	Powers reserved to states	Federalism's anchor — Anti-Federalists' victory

SELECTIVE INCORPORATION — the 14th Amendment is the bridge [5]

Originally, Bill of Rights only restrained the **FEDERAL** government. Through **selective incorporation**, the Supreme Court has applied most of the Bill of Rights to STATES via the **14th Amendment's Due Process Clause** — case-by-case, starting with **Gitlow v. New York (1925)**.

Key incorporated rights: 1st Amend. (Gitlow), 4th Amend. exclusionary rule (Mapp), 6th Amend. counsel (Gideon), 2nd Amend. (McDonald). **NOT incorporated:** 3rd Amend. quartering, 7th Amend. civil jury, grand jury (5th).

1st Amendment — the most-tested area

- **Establishment Clause:** gov can't establish religion. **Engel v. Vitale** — public school prayer = unconstitutional. *Lemon Test*: secular purpose, neutral effect, no entanglement.
- **Free Exercise Clause:** gov can't prohibit religious practice. **Wisconsin v. Yoder** — Amish exempted from compulsory schooling.
- **Speech:** protected unless **clear and present danger** (Schenck) → later **imminent lawless action** (Brandenburg). **Tinker** — symbolic speech in schools protected. **Citizens United** — corporate political speech protected.
- **Press:** **NYT v. US** — no prior restraint without overwhelming gov interest. *NYT v. Sullivan* — public officials must prove "actual malice" to win libel.
- **Unprotected speech:** obscenity, true threats, fighting words, defamation, incitement, child porn.

Due Process — Procedural vs Substantive [5]

- **Procedural** (5th & 14th): fair procedures (notice, hearing, lawyer). **Gideon** is procedural.
- **Substantive:** certain rights are so fundamental gov can't infringe regardless of procedure. **Roe v. Wade** rested on substantive due process (privacy).

CIVIL RIGHTS — the equal-protection arc

- **14th Amend. Equal Protection Clause** is the centerpiece — applied progressively to race, sex, sexual orientation.
- **Brown v. Board (1954)** overturned *Plessy* — "separate is inherently unequal." Landmark for civil rights movement.
- **Civil Rights Act (1964):** banned discrimination in public accommodations + employment by race/sex/religion/national origin. **Voting Rights Act (1965):** banned literacy tests, federal oversight of Southern elections.
- **Title IX (1972):** no sex discrimination in federally funded education.
- **Affirmative action:** race-conscious admissions. *Bakke* allowed; *Grutter* allowed limited; *SFFA v. Harvard (2023)* ended in higher ed.
- **Cite _Letter from Birmingham Jail_** for civil rights / civil disobedience prompts. "Just" vs "unjust" laws.

UNITS 4–5 | POLITICAL BELIEFS, BEHAVIORS & PARTICIPATION

POLITICAL IDEOLOGIES — match positions to ideology

Ideology	Economic position	Social position
Liberal	Pro government regulation; redistribution; expanded social safety net	Pro civil rights, abortion access, gay marriage, gun regulation
Conservative	Lower taxes; less regulation; free markets; smaller welfare state	Traditional values; restrictions on abortion; pro-2nd Amend.; stronger immigration enforcement
Libertarian	Free markets, minimal regulation, low taxes	Maximal personal liberty (pro-choice, pro-drug-legalization, anti-gov surveillance)
Populist	Pro working-class, anti-elite, anti-trade in some forms	Variable — often nationalist, immigration-restrictive

Political socialization: family > school > peers > media > religion > major events. Determines ideology formation.

Generational effects: Great Depression → New Deal Dems; 60s/70s → liberal social views; post-9/11 → polarization.

PUBLIC OPINION POLLING — for the Quant FRQ [5]

- **Random sample:** every member equal probability. Larger = more accurate. **Sample size of 1,000–1,500** typical for national poll.
- **Margin of error:** typically $\pm 3\%$. Two candidates within MoE = "statistical tie."
- **Question wording matters:** "welfare" vs "assistance to the poor" — same thing, different responses.
- **Tracking, exit, benchmark, push polls** — different purposes. Push polls are biased on purpose (campaigning disguised as polling).
- **Bandwagon effect** — people support whoever's leading. **Underdog effect** — sympathy boost. Both small.

POLITICAL PARTIES — functions + realignment

- **Functions:** nominate candidates; organize gov; mobilize voters; represent ideologies.
- **Critical realignments:** 1860 (Civil War — Republicans replace Whigs); 1932 (FDR — New Deal coalition); 1968 (Nixon's Southern Strategy starts the South's flip); 1980 (Reagan).
- **Two-party dominance** explained by **single-member districts + winner-take-all** (Duverger's law). Other reasons: ballot access laws, primary system, party identification.
- **Divided government:** opposing parties control White House and at least one chamber. Common since 1980; produces gridlock + presidential signing statements + executive orders.
- **Third parties** rarely win but shape agendas (Populists → Progressives absorbed; Ross Perot → deficit focus).

INTEREST GROUPS — pluralism in action [5]

- **Tactics:** lobbying, litigation (amicus briefs), grassroots mobilization, electioneering (PACs/super PACs), revolving door.
- **Iron Triangle:** agency + committee + interest group (e.g., DOD + Armed Services Committee + Lockheed).
- **Free rider problem:** people benefit from group without joining. Why Olson said small groups organize better.
- **Citizens United (2010)** + *SpeechNow* → birth of **Super PACs** (unlimited independent spending; can't coordinate with candidates).
- **Cite_Federalist 10** on factions/interest groups — Madison saw them as inevitable; large diverse republic checks them.

MEDIA — linkage institution + watchdog

- **Functions:** gatekeeper (which stories), scorekeeper (who's winning), watchdog (investigation).
- **Echo chambers + selective exposure** — partisan media (Fox, MSNBC); social-media algorithms reinforce.
- **FCC regulates broadcast** (not cable / internet much). **Equal time rule** for political candidates on broadcast TV.

VOTING — turnout, demographics, suppression

- **Turnout drivers:** education ↑, age ↑, income ↑ → all increase turnout. Married > single; whites > minorities (slightly); women > men (since 1980).
- **Why low turnout in U.S.** vs other democracies: voter registration is voter's responsibility (not auto), Tuesday elections (work day), no compulsory voting.
- **Voting Rights Act (1965)** + 24th Amend. (no poll tax) + 26th Amend. (18-year-olds, Vietnam era) expanded suffrage.
- **Voter ID laws, early voting, mail-in voting** are current battlegrounds. **Shelby County v. Holder (2013)** struck down VRA preclearance.
- **Demographic patterns** (general): Democrats favored by minorities, urban, young, college-educated, single women; Republicans by whites, rural, older, evangelical, married men.

PAGE 8 | FRQ STRATEGY · the 4 question types + scoring templates**FRQ 1 — CONCEPT APPLICATION (3 pts) — fastest, easiest 3 points**

You'll get a brief political scenario. 3 parts (A/B/C). 20 minutes total. Aim for 5 min — banking time for FRQ 4.

Part A ("Describe X"): 1 sentence. State the concept directly. **No need for examples or context.**

Part B ("Explain how the scenario reflects Y"): 2 sentences. Pull a specific fact from the scenario + connect to concept.

Part C ("Explain how Z might affect/change the situation"): 2 sentences. Logical "if-then" reasoning.

[5] Each part needs to use "because," name a concept by its formal term, AND reference the scenario directly. "Federalism is the division of power between national and state governments" → 1 pt, full clarity.

FRQ 2 — QUANTITATIVE ANALYSIS (4 pts) — graph/chart interpretation

You'll get a graph, table, or map of political data. 4 parts (A/B/C/D). 20 min total.

Part A ("Identify") — pure data point. "In 2020, voter turnout was 67%." Don't over-explain.

Part B ("Describe a pattern") — 1 trend across the data. "Turnout increases with education level."

Part C ("Draw a conclusion") — explanation linking data to political concept. Use "this suggests..." or "this implies..."

Part D ("Explain implication for [politics/policy/elections]") — connect data trend to a political outcome. **Cite a concept by name** (turnout, mobilization, polarization, etc.).

[5] The 4-vs-5 differentiator on this FRQ: the C and D parts must reference SPECIFIC political science concepts ("linkage institutions," "voter mobilization," "polarization") — not just generic observations.

FRQ 3 — SCOTUS COMPARISON (4 pts) — the rubric is mechanical

You'll get a non-required SCOTUS case (facts + holding). 4 parts. 20 min total. Run the 4-step recipe from Page 3.

Part A (1 pt — Identify shared constitutional clause): "Both cases involve the [1st Amendment Free Speech Clause / 14th Amendment Equal Protection Clause / Commerce Clause]."

Part B (1 pt — Explain how the required case's facts/reasoning relate): Name the required case + 1-sentence facts + 1-sentence holding. "In *Tinker v. Des Moines*, students wore black armbands to protest Vietnam. The Court held that students don't shed constitutional rights at the schoolhouse gate."

Part C (1 pt — Explain how the cases differ or similar reasoning applies): Compare. "Like *Tinker*, the new case involves symbolic speech in a school setting; the Court would likely apply the same protection."

Part D (1 pt — Explain how an interest group / political institution might respond): 1–2 sentences. "The ACLU might file an amicus brief supporting the student, citing *Tinker's* precedent."

FRQ 4 — ARGUMENT ESSAY (6 pts) — 17% of your grade. THE deciding FRQ.

40 minutes. Take a position on a constitutional/political issue using the required documents. The rubric:

Pts	What earns it	How to bag it
1	Thesis / Claim [FLOOR—4]	Defensible thesis with reasoning. "Although [counter], [position] because [R1] and [R2]."
1	Evidence 1: from a required foundational document [STRETCH—5]	REQUIRED — must name a doc + use a specific argument from it. (See Page 2's doc-to-prompt matching.)
1	Evidence 2: from another foundational doc OR from course knowledge [FLOOR—4]	Specific second piece — could be a SCOTUS case, a 2nd doc, or a policy/historical event.
1	Reasoning explaining how/why evidence supports thesis [STRETCH—5]	1–2 sentences after EACH piece of evidence connecting it back to your claim.
1	Responds to alternative perspective via refutation/concession/rebuttal [STRETCH—5]	"While some argue [opposing view], this overlooks [your evidence]. Therefore [restate thesis with nuance]."
1	Sometimes a complexity / additional rebuttal point [STRETCH—5]	Some years have an additional rubric point — write a strong conclusion either way.

[5] The single biggest 4-vs-5 differentiator on FRQ 4: getting the FOUNDATIONAL DOC point. If she remembers no other strategy, she should remember: "My argument essay must cite by name one of the 9 foundational docs and quote/paraphrase a specific argument from it."

PAGE 9 | TRAPS, 4-vs-5 LADDER & RUBRIC-WINNING PHRASES

MCQ TRAP MENU — the patterns to recognize and eliminate [4]

- **Wrong constitutional clause** — answer cites Equal Protection when scenario is about Free Exercise. Eliminate immediately.
- **Wrong branch's power** — "the President can declare war" — wrong, that's Congress. Watch for crossed wires.
- **Anachronism** — answer references an institution/law that didn't exist yet. ("Citizens United influenced the 1990 election" — wrong, decided 2010.)
- **Too extreme** — "always / never / completely" — usually wrong; political reality is hedged.
- **Conservative/liberal swap** — answer attributes a typical liberal position to conservatives or vice versa. Know the ideological menu (Page 7).
- **Right answer to wrong question** — answer is true but doesn't address the prompt. Re-read the stem before locking in.
- **Source-based MCQs** (most of them): identify the document type → identify era → identify perspective → THEN match to options.

THE 4-vs-5 LADDER — what 5-scorers add on top of the 4 floor

Tier 4 student writes...	Tier 5 student adds...
"The Constitution divides power among branches."	" <i>Federalist 51</i> argues 'ambition must be made to counteract ambition,' which is reflected in the formal checks of veto, override, and judicial review."
"This case is similar to <i>Brown v. Board</i> ."	"Both cases turn on the 14th Amendment Equal Protection Clause . In <i>Brown</i> , the Court held that 'separate is inherently unequal.' The same reasoning applies because..."
"Voter turnout is higher among educated people."	"As education rises, turnout increases — reflecting the resource model of participation . This implies linkage institutions like parties target educated voters more directly."
Cites a doc vaguely ("the <i>Federalist Papers</i> say")	Names the specific number (<i>Federalist 10</i> vs <i>51</i> vs <i>70</i> vs <i>78</i>) AND quotes/paraphrases the specific argument
States thesis once	Restates thesis in conclusion + adds a complexity move ("While in the short term..., in the long term...")
Names a SCOTUS case	Names case + year + clause + holding in one tight sentence
"Interest groups influence policy."	"Through iron triangles — long-term alliances of agencies, committees, and interest groups — policy is shaped before reaching public debate, as Madison feared in <i>Federalist 10</i> ."

THE "ALWAYS SAY THIS" RUBRIC PHRASES — what graders search for [5]

Move	Drop this phrase in
Thesis	"Although [counterview], [main claim] because [reason 1] and [reason 2]."
Foundational doc citation	"In [<i>Federalist 51</i> / <i>Brutus 1</i> / etc.], [author] argues that '[specific paraphrase]'. This supports my thesis because [direct connection]."
Reasoning	"This evidence supports my thesis because [explicit causal link between evidence and claim]."
SCOTUS comparison	"Both cases involve the [clause name]. In [<i>required case</i>], the Court held [holding], establishing the principle that [reasoning]. Applied here, the same reasoning [supports / does not support] [outcome]."
Rebuttal / counter	"While some argue [opposing view], this overlooks [your evidence]. The stronger interpretation is [restate thesis] because [reason]."
Quant FRQ conclusion	"This data implies [political consequence] because [linkage to a political-science concept like polarization, mobilization, or partisan realignment]."
Federalism	"Under the 10th Amendment , powers not delegated to the federal government are reserved to the states. However, the Necessary and Proper Clause grants Congress implied powers, as established in <i>McCulloch v. Maryland</i> ."

TEST-DAY EXECUTION CHECKLIST

For a 4 — bag ALL of these: ✓ MCQ: 36+ correct (eliminate, never blank) ✓ FRQ 1: all 3 parts answered with concept named ✓ FRQ 2: data point identified + pattern described ✓ FRQ 3: clause identified + required case named ✓ FRQ 4: thesis + 2 evidence (at least one foundational doc, even if vague)

For a 5 — add these on top: ✓ MCQ: 41+ correct ✓ FRQ 1–3: every part includes a **named concept** ✓ FRQ 3: required case's **clause + holding** stated explicitly ✓ FRQ 4: foundational doc cited by **specific name + paraphrased argument** ✓ Reasoning sentence after every piece of evidence ✓ Counter+rebuttal in FRQ 4 conclusion

THE ONE THING THAT MATTERS MOST [5]: NAME THINGS SPECIFICALLY. "The *Federalist Papers* say..." earns 0; "*Federalist 51* argues that..." earns the point. "A Supreme Court case said..." earns 0; "*Marbury v. Madison* (1803) established judicial review under Article III" earns the point. **Specificity is the entire 4-vs-5 difference on AP Gov.**

If you do nothing else: memorize the 9 docs (Page 2) and 15 cases with their CLAUSES (Page 3), and use the FRQ templates (Page 8). That's how you get the score you're targeting.

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